

Undying optimism

In his book titled *There's Always This Year: On Basketball and Ascension*, the author Hanif Abdurraqib uses basketball (the book is structured like an NBA game, with four sections or 'quarters') as a **mesh through which to view life**, both his own and those of his community and some of its stars.

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How often has a sports fan said, "There's always next year," consoling and sympathising with another who supports the team which failed to win the title yet again? It speaks to the undying optimism of the fan, and the reason for it. Hope springs eternal — think of the RCB fan who had to wait so long for his team to deliver.

So it was intriguing to see a book titled *There's Always This Year: On Basketball and Ascension*. It is about the sport, and being about sport it is also about lots more. The author Hanif Abdurraqib uses basketball (the book is structured like an NBA game, with four sections or 'quarters') as a mesh through which to view life, both his own and those of his community and some of its stars like Michael Jordan.

It is part memoir, part cultural and political commentary, part biography, the whole being greater than the sum of its parts.

Here is Abdurraqib on LeBron James (**in pic**): "I have sat at the feet of poets who told me that there is power in withholding. In not offering the parts of yourself that people are most eager to see. In the high school career of LeBron James, there was access to his dominance, but not always access to whatever struggles he might have been pushing through. And it proved hard for people to stay fascinated with dominance, especially if they were on the losing side of it, especially in consideration of who was doing the dominating."



Abdurraqib and James were born and raised in Ohio a year apart; the sportsman's ascent is contrasted with the author's less dramatic rise as a recipient of the Macarthur 'genius' grant and one of the leading cultural commentators. Growing up, Abdurraqib was sent to prison for petty theft, while at the same age James ("the best high school basketball player in America") was driving to school in expensive cars. **Basketball lifted one man from the disadvantages of colour and class while poetry and writing was the other's redemption.**

When James left Cleveland Cavaliers, they lost 63 games. Abdurraqib tells us gently, "There was

pleasure in watching this aimless disaster of a team. Veteran castoffs who had been given up on, young players who seemed, mostly, bewildered by the pace and intensity of the games, forced to play minutes because someone had to, after all. At a certain point, it seemed anyone who could run up and down the court would do."

The strength of the book lies in its digression as it moves from movies and songs to people and places. The author pulls the threads together like an artist seemingly playing around with colours, and suddenly an identifiable picture emerges.

The basketball is both incidental and central to the story. I loved the description of the floater: "The most romantic shot in the game when done right, guided toward the rim with a heave and a wish, like saying goodbye to a person you never wanted to leave."